Session plan 8: Experimental studies

Thu 22.10.26, 14:15–15:45 · Room 4.B51 · Basic reading: AJ ch. 1 (pp. 1–33); additional: GG ch. 1 (pp. 1–17) · Applied reading: Haas et al. (2024), *Beyond Persuasion: Protest's direct behavioral impact on bystanders* · Presenters: **Chantal Hüsler, Nina Franziska Jäggi**

Learning goals: students can (1) explain why comparing insured and uninsured people mixes the effect of insurance with selection bias (difference in means = average causal effect + selection bias); (2) explain why random assignment removes selection bias, and why it needs large groups (law of large numbers); (3) read a balance table; (4) name what experiments can't do: ethics, unrandomizable treatments, cost, noncompliance, external validity; (5) say whether their own treatment could be randomized.

Before class: presentation slides in OLAT (due Wed 21.10, 12:00)? · seminar questions 8–9 uploaded? · grading sheet `session08_handwritten.pdf` ready · board pen for two lists ("why the coin helps" / "why we can't just do it") and the show-of-hands counts · deck in speaker view (press S)

Checkpoints: 14:32 start the live randomization · 14:49 start "What experiments can't do" · **15:05 end group exercise** · **15:08 presentation starts** (25 min max., then discussion until 15:42)

Time	Slide	Content	Interaction	Guiding questions	If behind
14:15–14:20	2	**Hook**: back to attendance (session 6); flip a coin?	Two board lists	Would you trust it? Would it be allowed?	
14:20–14:25	3	**Are insured people healthier?** NHIS 2009, married men (AJ Table 1.1, pp. 3–5); reveal rows one by one	Question first, then rows	Does insurance make people healthier? What else differs?	
14:25–14:29	4	**Selection bias in words** (AJ eq. 1.3, p. 10); Khuzdar and Maria in reserve (pp. 6–8)	Question	Is the selection bias positive or negative?	Skip question
14:29–14:32	5	**Just randomize**: RAND HIE, 3,958 people, 14 plans (AJ pp. 12, 16–18)	Question	Why should a lottery fix the problem?	
14:32–14:40	6	**Live randomization**: even vs. odd birthday; commute > 30 min, sibling, coffee today	Show of hands; counts on the board	Are the groups alike? Are two people alike?	Two characteristics only
14:40–14:43	7	**Checking for balance**: RAND Table 1.3 (AJ pp. 16–20); only "female" exceeds chance	Compare with the room	Why check balance at all?	
14:43–14:46	8	**Why size matters**: two people vs. thousands; law of large numbers (AJ pp. 12–13)	Question	How close were our two groups?	1 min
14:46–14:49	9	**What RAND found**: more care, no better health (AJ Table 1.4, pp. 20–23)	Predict, then reveal	Free care: healthier?	
14:49–14:55	10	**What experiments can't do**: ethics, unrandomizable, cost, noncompliance (Oregon, AJ pp. 24–29, one line), external validity	Match with board list	What could we randomize instead of attendance?	Skip attendance question
14:55–15:05	11	**Pairs** on seminar questions 8.1–8.2 + "could you randomize it?"; plenary on 8.3	6 min pairs, 4 min plenary	Would randomization solve selection bias completely?	No plenary; 8.3 into session 9; **hard stop 15:05**
15:05–15:07	12	**Can you randomize a protest?** Lead-in to the applied reading	Two or three guesses	Treatment, control, outcome?	Skip
15:07–15:08	13	Hand over			

Time	Slide	Content	Interaction	Guiding questions	If behind
15:08–15:33	—	**Student presentation** (25 min max.): summary and critique ~10 min, alternative design ~15 min	Presentation; grade with the sheet		Signal at 20 min
15:33–15:42	—	**Discussion** to improve the proposal (prompts below)	Plenary	See prompts below	
15:42–15:45	14–16	Session 9 at **16:00** (new start time), same room (AJ ch. 2; Ndiaye & Schertenleib, Ziblatt et al.); take-home exercise II goes online in session 9	Admin		
optional	17	Backup: lab, survey or field? (GG ch. 1, pp. 8–17)	Question	How "field" is a paid walk past a protest?	Skip

Discussion prompts (if the room is quiet): Not everyone on the treatment route noticed the strike: what does that do to the comparison of routes (assigned vs. treated, as in Oregon)? · Paid recruits on an assigned walk: who are they, and do the results travel to real passers-by? · Fridays for Future in Berlin as a "most likely case": would a smaller or less popular protest do the same? · Only about half came back for the follow-up: what could that do to the long-run results? · Donations rose but attitudes didn't: persuasion or "behavioral activation"?

Grading (0–5 each, 15/30 = pass): clarity · understanding · critique quality · reasoning · feasibility · discussion. Both presenters, one grade.

Notes during class: